CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

BAKER IN THE AI ERA

Two different jobs were sharing this card. The one you can actually start pays $37,160 with a ceiling under $50K — the pastry-chef pay belongs to another occupation entirely.

★ TL;DR — NO as framed. This card is re-scoped to Baker, because BLS puts restaurant pastry chefs inside Chefs and Head Cooks ($62,470, 5+ years' experience) — the $37,160 occupation here is production and retail bakers. Bakers: median $37,160 (BLS, May 2025), top decile only $49,020, growth +6%, ~36,500 openings a year — but net growth is only ~1,450 jobs a year, so almost all of those openings are replacement churn. The beginner starts toward the floor decile of $28,120. The doors below lead out of the ceiling. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

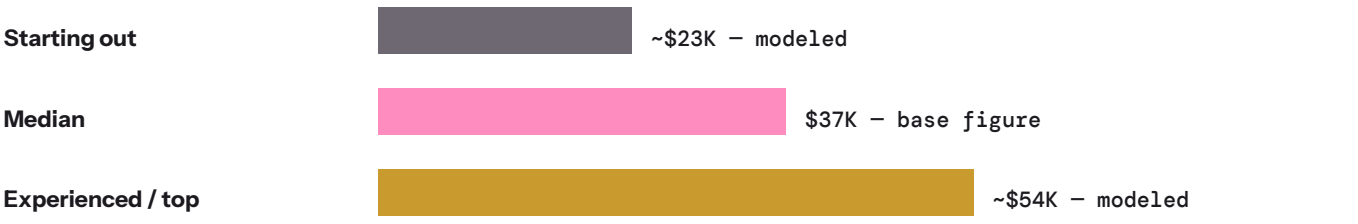
OUR TAKE: NO — NOT IN 2027

MEDIAN ~$37K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

- Fails as a start because: the occupation's own top decile is $49,020 — there is no pay ladder inside Bakers; every rung above ~$49K requires leaving the occupation.
- The title error: 'pastry chef' pay ($62,470) belongs to Chefs and Head Cooks and its 5+ year experience gate; the old card priced a production-baker occupation with a chef's title.
- Not an AI story: nothing mixes, proofs or decorates by robot. The live pressure is deskilling — grocery in-store bakeries increasingly finish-bake factory-made frozen product, capping the skill the entry seat can build.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Baker is a ~$37K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A BAKER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Mix, proof, shape and bake breads and pastries at production scale
- ✓ Run ovens, mixers and sheeters — increasingly automated plant equipment
- ✓ Finish and display product in grocery and retail bakery departments
- ✓ Hold food-safety and consistency standards across long, early shifts

Think: a factory craft shift that starts at 3 a.m. — skilled hands, industrial ceiling.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Old, mechanical, plant-level automation that is already priced into the outlook: high-volume mixing and baking lines for standardised goods (BLS describes them inside the occupation). No generative AI or robot does the baker's work.	Judgment of dough by touch, fermentation timing, decoration and custom work — the hand skills survive; what shrinks is how much of the grocery seat still uses them.

⚠ **The optional 1–2 year culinary or baking programme is not the entry requirement (BLS: no formal educational credential) and does not buy the pastry-chef title — that promotion runs through the Chefs occupation and its 5+ years of experience. Don't pay tuition to enter a $37K occupation with a $49K ceiling.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ The door is genuinely open: no credential, employers train on the job ✓ Demand is steady: +6% growth and ~36,500 openings a year ✓ Production skill transfers directly into catering and food businesses	✗ Median $37,160, floor decile $28,120, top decile $49,020 — the whole range is thin ✗ Early mornings, nights, weekends, heat, burns and back strain are the schedule ✗ ~96% of openings are replacement churn, not growth

Good fit? You want food work now and a business later — and you'll use bakery skill as capital, not as the destination.

Bad fit? You pictured restaurant pastry-chef pay and artistry from a production-baker seat.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PIVOT TO Caterer	DOOR B — PIVOT TO Restaurant Manager
Catering is where production-baking skill turns into event money: a beginner can be hired into catering work immediately, and a permitted own business is legally openable in year one (the permit stack is the real gate — see the Caterer roadmap). The labelled anchor is the Food Service Managers median, $69,390 (BLS, May 2025), +6%, ~38,800 openings a year. First move: add one celebration-cake or event-dessert offering to your skill set and price it against local caterers.	Food Service Managers: median $69,390, +6%, ~38,800 openings a year, formal requirement a high school diploma plus less than 5 years of related experience. The printed ladder runs floor ~$35K → supervisor $45,370 → manager $69,390. Bakery and café operations experience is exactly the related experience this ladder counts. First move: take a lead or key-holder shift in your current shop and own one number — waste, labour, or morning sell-through.

Smart move: Sell reliability at production scale. The baker who never misses a 3 a.m. shift and can run the whole board is the one caterers and operators recruit — that reputation is worth more than the title.

Where you land after: You land where the baking skill is an ingredient, not the whole job: running events, or running the room — at the $69K anchor instead of the $49K ceiling.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
READ THE	ENTER WHERE	PICK YOUR	BUILD THE	TAKE THE	EXIT THE

STEP 1 — Read the real numbers

FREE · TODAY

- Read the BLS Bakers page: $37,160 median, $49,020 top decile, no formal credential required
- Read the Chefs page too — that is where 'pastry chef' actually lives, behind 5+ years of experience

STEP 2 — Enter where the skill compounds

WEEKS 1-4

- Choose employers whose bakers touch real production (scratch bakery, catering commissary) over pure bake-off finishing
- Say early that you want lead and event work — that is the direction of both doors

STEP 3 — Pick your door

MONTH 2

- Door A if you want your own book: catering events and a permitted business in year one
- Door B if you want the salaried climb: supervisor duties toward the $69,390 manager median

STEP 4 — Build the proof piece

MONTHS 2-6

- Catering route: one priced, photographed event menu you can produce solo from a commissary
- Manager route: own a number for a quarter — waste %, morning sell-through, labour hours

STEP 5 — Take the flat permits seriously

WHEN REQUIRED

- Food handler's certification where your state requires it — hours, often within weeks of hire
- For Door A: map your jurisdiction's catering permit and commissary rules before taking deposits

STEP 6 — Exit the ceiling on schedule

YEAR 1

- By month 12 you should hold a lead title, an event book, or a supervisor conversation — not just hours
- Revisit pastry-chef ambitions only via the Chefs ladder, with eyes open about its 5-year gate

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- ☐ Today: read the BLS Bakers page — median, top decile, and the no-credential entry line.
- ☐ Days 1–30: applications out to scratch bakeries and catering commissaries; door chosen.
- ☐ Days 31–60: producing daily; proof piece (event menu or owned metric) in progress.
- ☐ Days 61–90: lead duties or a first paid event under your belt.
- ☐ Day 90: you're building toward a $69K anchor seat instead of pressing against a $49K ceiling.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ BAKE THE SKILL. SELL THE EVENT. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.